Why clicks aren’t converting

CharmLink premium-link funnel analysis — measured against production

26 August 2026 · Data window 22 Mar – 26 Aug 2026 · 708,845 events · Source: `charmlink_events`, `honeypot_logs` (Supabase project `vhdgfcrjjscnhcdsqsgs`)

Summary

There is a real, fixable technical barrier between a click and OnlyFans — but it accounts for roughly a fifth of the gap, not all of it. **About one in eight recorded “premium clicks” is a tap on a link that cannot reach OnlyFans by construction.** The remaining ~84% do arrive. If conversions are near zero rather than merely lower than expected, the destination page is also a factor.

The reported click number is inflated by **~19%**. The true figure for the measured window is approximately **169,300**, not 202,198.

> **The bot trap was catching humans. Of 33,517 honeypot hits, 86.6% carried mobile browser user-agents and 0.12% carried bot user-agents — and every hit banned that IP for 24 hours.**

1. The honeypot was a human trap

When a request to `POST /api/links/[creator]` failed any of its gates, the API returned a payload containing exactly one visible link, labelled “Loading…”, pointing at `/api/honeypot`. A real visitor who was falsely rejected saw a page with one tappable item on it and tapped it.

Honeypot evidence (10 May – 26 Aug 2026)	Value	Read
Total hits	33,517	—
Distinct IPs banned	8,712	24h lockout each
Hits per IP	3.85	banned users re-banned
Mobile browser user-agents	29,028 (86.6%)	real people
Bot user-agents	**41 (0.12%)**	**intended targets**

The failure was self-reinforcing. A banned IP is served the decoy page by middleware, so the visitor’s next attempt produced another rejection, another “Loading…” link, and another ban. The 3.85 hits-per-IP average is that loop. On carrier-grade NAT a single banned address can front thousands of subscribers.

2. The click funnel, measured

Outcome	Clicks	Share
Reached OnlyFans — direct navigation	162,967	80.6%
Reached OnlyFans — via /r/ interstitial	6,355	3.1%
Trapped in the honeypot decoy	**25,522**	**12.6%**
Abandoned at age gate	79	0.04%
Total recorded premium clicks	202,198	100%

Two distinct effects inflate the headline number: **12.6%** are dead clicks that never leave the site, and a further **~3%** are the interstitial path being counted twice — once when the link is tapped, again when the redirect completes.

Trend since the decoy shipped

Month	Reached OF	Trapped	% trapped
March 2026	267	0	0.0%
April 2026	190	0	0.0%
May 2026	5,784	828	12.0%
June 2026	62,635	11,973	14.9%
July 2026	55,547	6,968	11.1%
August 2026	44,850	5,753	11.3%

Zero before May, then double digits from the moment the hardened links API went live, sustained for four months.

3. Why real users were being rejected

The likeliest driver, given that 86.6% of trapped traffic is mobile and it spans 95 countries, is that **the HMAC link token was bound to the client IP address**.

The token was minted during server rendering using the IP of that request, then verified against the IP of the browser's follow-up POST moments later. On mobile networks those two addresses frequently differ — WiFi/cellular handoff, carrier NAT rotation, IPv6 privacy addressing, CDN edge variance. Every mismatch failed verification and dropped a genuine visitor into the rejection path described above. A secondary contributor is the 30-requests-per-minute rate limit, also keyed on a shared IP.

4. Hypotheses the data ruled out

Three plausible explanations were tested and eliminated. Recording them so they are not re-investigated:

Hypothesis	Verdict	Evidence
Bare `onlyfans://` deep link discards the creator's profile path	Not active	`deeplink_enabled` is false on all 107 active premium links
Age-gate friction is losing visitors	Immaterial	Only 3 of 107 links are gated; 98.8% completion (6,434 → 6,355)
Age-confirm rate limit traps users in a loop	Not at scale	Real defect in code, but only 79 abandonments total

Still unquantified. The `x-safari-https://` scheme — dead since iOS 14.5 — remains on the live path for iOS Instagram clicks on non-sensitive links, which is 104 of 107 links. Its drop-off cannot be measured from the events table.

5. Two caveats on the dashboard numbers

- **Bot views are structurally zero.** `is_bot` is hard-coded false on every click event, and page views take the flag from the client, which always sends false. All 708,845 events carry `is_bot = false`. The "Bot Views" metric has never reported anything.
- **Page views are likely double-counted for Instagram.** Instagram is 43.9% of page views but only 10.5% of clicks. The probable cause is the automatic in-app-browser escape: the WebView records one view, hands off to Safari, which records a second, and the click lands there. This would inflate the denominator of every CTR figure. Strong hypothesis, not yet verified — it needs session-level correlation to confirm.

6. Changes shipped

Committed to `claude/repo-review-ed7w66` as `c7460a7`. Type-check, production build and lint all pass; a token round-trip suite covers the new scheme and both legacy-fallback directions.

#	Change	Effect
1	Rejection payload is now an empty list instead of a followable honeypot link	Removes the trap entirely — the 12.6%
2	Link tokens no longer bound to client IP; legacy tokens still accepted during rollout	Stops rejecting real mobile visitors in the first place
3	Honeypot bans only when the request looks automated, never on `ref=d1`	Ends the 24h lockouts and the re-ban loop

The genuine trap — an off-screen, `aria-hidden`, non-tabbable anchor that no real user can reach — is untouched and still logs every hit, so monitoring value is preserved.

7. What to do next

- **Do not treat this as an OnlyFans page-optimisation problem yet.** Give the three fixes a week in production first. Any visitor banned during the affected period was seeing a decoy page, so their true reach rate is currently unknowable.
- **Re-baseline the click metric.** Historical premium clicks are ~19% high. Comparisons that straddle the fix date will show an apparent drop that is really the phantom clicks disappearing.
- **Deduplicate click tracking** so one journey counts once — the interstitial path currently records both the tap and the redirect.
- **Fix the reporting defects:** stop hard-coding `is_bot`, and confirm the Instagram double-count before trusting any CTR figure.
- **Remove the dead `x-safari-https://` scheme** from the iOS Instagram click path.

All figures are aggregate queries run directly against the production database on 26 August 2026. No individual event rows or personal data were extracted. Row counts and percentages are reproducible from the queries recorded in the engineering session transcript.